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UC-Berkeley forums to foster discussions of war in Iraq

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(*#_Company_Name_#*) BERKELEY, Calif. -- With war in Iraq looming, University of California at Berkeley administrators have created an open forum for politically active student groups to speak their minds.

At the end of last semester, Chancellor Robert Berdahl created a committee of campus and city leaders to prevent disruptive clashes.

Although this is the first committee of its kind, the Tang Center put on a similar counseling program to help students deal with the psychological effects of the 1991 Gulf War.

"It is incumbent upon us now, since we will most likely see protests about this issue, that we communicate effectively with constituent groups both on and off campus," said Associate Chancellor John Cummins, chairman of the new committee.

Because of the tensions surrounding both sides of the conflict, open dialogue will be encouraged through debate and discussions, said Associated Students of the University of California President Jesse Gabriel, who is on the committee.

In campuswide forums, university professors will be invited to address political, military and humanitarian issues surrounding the war.

The first forum will take place three days following the beginning of any U.S. military action in Iraq, Cummins said.

"The basic core value of the university is to maintain a free and open space for education to occur, for there to be discussion and dialogue and debate," Cummins said. "We want to preserve that on campus."

Other programs for students will include counseling sessions at the Tang Center, safe spaces for students to comfortably speak and an online information site.

"Individual professors may have particular views, but the intent is to have a balanced presentation of issues around the war," Cummins said. "It would be a very broad-ranging discussion."

Preparedness is all the more necessary because many UC-Berkeley students could personally be affected by a war, Gabriel said.

"A lot of what we do is just making sure we're prepared," he said. "Obviously there are people who are going to have strong political feelings about this war -- it's important to help students directly affected by this war."

Responding to last year's clashes between student groups about conflicts in the Middle East, the chancellor formed a Middle East committee to suggest educational programs, debates and discussions.

The Middle East committee sponsored guest speakers such as former Israeli Prime Minister Ehud Barak and well-known Palestinian intellectual Edward Said.

That committee laid the groundwork for the chancellor's new effort.

Despite the ever-increasing likelihood of war, the program is still in its planning phase, Cummins said.

Because the committee will not begin hosting events until the war begins, some students said it may not adequately address preventative measures.

"If it were up to us, this would be a committee on how to end the war, on organizing and stuff," said Marc de Giere, a member of the Berkeley Stop the War Coalition.

De Giere said he hopes student organizations will take an active role in the committee's activities.

The 26-person committee includes faculty and students, and a rabbi, a Christian leader and a Muslim community leader, Gabriel said.

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